



free will
and
determinism

against
compatibilist
free will

A large red circle with a slight drop shadow, containing white text. The text is arranged in three lines, centered within the circle.

**against
incompatibilist
free will**

This argument seems to show that the combination of four theses — that No one has any choice about the past, no choice about the laws of nature, the no choice principle, and determinism — rules out free will.

Since the first three of these theses seem quite plausible, the argument seems to show that if determinism is true, there are no free actions — and hence that free will is incompatible with determinism.

1. Free will is incompatible with determinism.
 2. If Libertarianism is true, then there is no free will.
-

C. There is no free will.

The master argument against the reality of free will

Real/|the master argument:

The consequence argument is a defense of premise (1). If you believe in free will, and find the consequence argument persuasive, it looks tempting to reply to the master argument by denying premise (2).

But, we'll see now, this argument can also be given a plausible defense.

One way to introduce this defense is with the following quote from

David Hume:

Hume's basic thought is that there is a big difference between free actions and actions which are random or chance.

Here's a thought experiment:

Now ask yourself: is Alex's choice free? It seems very clear that it is not. It is undetermined by facts prior to the relevant run of the Randomizer, but it is random. It is not up to Alex what he does; and free actions have to be up to the person doing the action.

This suggests:

But now consider the idea that free will requires the falsity of determinism. If this is true, then it must be that free actions (or their immediate causes) are undetermined:

But consider what an undetermined act would be. It would be an action which is such that the entire history of the universe up to that point is consistent with the act either happening or not happening. So if the act happens, nothing **makes** it happen. In particular, nothing that the person who does the action, or anyone else, does makes the action happen.

2. If an action is undetermined, then the agent does not control whether it happens.

One might instead call into question the second premise.

There are two main arguments in favor of this premise.

The first is related to the “Randomizer” example we have already discussed. The idea is that if some action of mine is undetermined, it is just **as if** I had a Randomizer implanted in in my brain. What could the relevant difference be between the Randomizer and some non-deterministic process in my brain?

1. If Libertarianism is true, then, if there are free actions, those actions are undetermined.
 2. If an action is undetermined, then it is random.
 3. If Libertarianism is true, then, if there are free actions, those actions are random. (1,2)
 4. No random acts are free.
-

C. If Libertarianism is true, then there are no free actions.

The control argument

One answer to this question relies on the idea of **agent causation**. In many cases, I cause something by participating in some event; for example, I cause my arm to go up by participating in the event of deciding to raise my arm.



6. If $\det A$ is true, then A has any

and none has any choice about whether,

1. No one has any choice about events which



happened in the distant past.

2. None has any choice about DIDS. ATJR.

future is not inconsistent with the state of the

varlatatire + thelavsfatire.

nature say that if DINS ARE happy,

3. If determined, the only one

4. If determinism is true, the laws of

then DECISION happens. (3)

theorie about the fact that if DNR

of interest.

about whether @.

5. No one has any choice about what the laws



7. If none has about choice about whether P,

if P , then Q , then one has any choice

then DECISION. (4,5)

choice about DECISION (2, 6, 7)

C. If determinis_true , then no_one_has_any

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1. If Libertarian is true, then, if there

3. If Libertarianism is true, then, if there

4. No irreflexive acts are free.

C. If Libertarianism is true, there are



no free actors.

raindon.(1,2)

unleashed.



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deciding to raise my arm.

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We can lay out this puzzle in terms of the following master argument against the

reality of free will.

believe in free will rejects premise (2).

Compatibility believers in free will reject premise (1). An incompatibilist

Now, so far we have been given no reason to think that either premise (2)

for (2), and one for (3).

or premise (3) is true. We're now going to look at two arguments — one

A large orange circle with a subtle drop shadow, containing the text 'against compatibilist free will' in white, bold, sans-serif font.

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